UNIVERSITY OF THE WITWATERSRAND, JOHANNESBURG | WSoE Wits School of Education

WITS AHEAD RESEARCH GROUP

The AHEAD Fortnightly

Issue 4 · 12 November 2026 · Wits School of Education, University of the Witwatersrand

For dis two weeks, di matter don move from weda students dey use AI to how well dem dey use am: new studies from Australia, South Africa and Nigeria agree sey habit and how deep person dey engage, no be just access or how policy dey read, na wetin dey predict beta learning and beta future for graduates. Institutions no dey react di same way: some dey go back to in-person exams and tougher policy against cheating, oda ones, including Wits wit dem new Global Higher Education Futures Centre, dey choose to build di pedagogy and research capacity instead. Statistics South Africa third-quarter figures remind us why dis matter here: youth unemployment drop small to 47.3%, so di return for every hour of study still dey wait to be earn. For Wits AHEAD, di work remain di same: to helep graduates turn capability, no be just access, to opportunity.

THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1

NEWS · 11 NOVEMBER 2026 · UNITED KINGDOM

Office for Students tells universities to bring back in-person exams to protect assessment from AI

Office for Students, di body wey dey oversee universities for England, don tell universities say dem need to think about going back to face to face exams wey no gree open book, viva voce and practical tasks, so dat assessment go still dey valid as AI dey spread well well. Di guidance come after one four month study wey dem do wit Advance HE, wey base on tori wit around 300 students and staff for more than 120 schools, and e show say AI use dey everywhere, and say some assessments no fit work well again. Na di first time di regulator don lay out di kain AI wahala for school wey fit make dem take action, including say school fit get lower quality award.

> **Why e matter:** Wits AHEAD first pillar na generative AI for higher education, including assessment and integrity. Na im make wen one national regulator move from just guidance to action wey fit bite, e dey show sign wey oda systems, including South Africa own, go dey watch well well.

Times Higher Education · timeshighereducation.com · Read am for source

Luckhurst, G. (2026, November 11). OfS pushes in-person exams to 'protect sector's reputation'. *Times Higher Education*. timeshighereducation.com/news/ofs-pushes-person-exams-protect-sectors-reputation

2

REPORT · 11 NOVEMBER 2026 · UNITED KINGDOM

Graduates' wellbeing and civic contribution should be tracked alongside pay, British Academy argues

British Academy talk say di way dem dey measure wetin make graduate successful too narrow, because e dey focus only on salary. Di Academy want dem begin track work life balance, long term health and civic engagement too. Dem point to one government survey wey show say 24% of graduates dey volunteer well well at least once every month, compare to 17% for people wey no graduate, and dem suggest say make dem link higher education data wit health and crime data so dem fit see fuller picture.

> **Why e matter:** Wits AHEAD fourth pillar na about graduate capability and work wey dem fit do pass di first job. Wen one national academy dey push make dem measure outcome wider, e dey tally wit how di group dey define "success" for dia own candidates.

British Academy, reported by Times Higher Education · timeshighereducation.com · Read am for source

Luckhurst, G. (2026, November 11). Graduates' work-life balance 'should be tracked alongside pay'. *Times Higher Education*. timeshighereducation.com/news/graduates-work-life-balance-should-be-tracked-alongside-pay

3

REPORT · 10 NOVEMBER 2026 · SOUTH AFRICA

Youth unemployment eases slightly to 47.3% as overall unemployment rises to 33.7% in the third quarter of 2026

Di official unemployment rate climb by 0.1 percentage point to 33.7% for Q3 2026, as employment grow by 101,000 to 16.8 million, but di workforce grow pass dat. Youth unemployment (15 to 34) drop small by 0.1 percentage point to 47.3%: unemployed youth drop by 23,000 to 5.0 million, while employed youth drop by 5,000 to 5.5 million.

> **Why e matter:** Dis na di number di group dey use for graduate pathways and just transitions. Pillar 4 dey ask whether AI dey close or open dis gap for dis same group of people.

Statistics South Africa · statssa.gov.za · Read am for source

Statistics South Africa. (2026, November 10). *Quarterly Labour Force Survey (QLFS): Q3 2026* [Press release]. statssa.gov.za/publications/P0211/Media%20Release%20QLFS%20Q3%202026.pdf

RESEARCH AND REPORTS

Wits opens a Global Higher Education Futures Centre, with a dedicated generative AI pedagogy hub

University of the Witwatersrand · 9 November 2026 · Pillar 6: Responsible AI and policy. For Pillar 6, one South African university dey build dia own framework to think about how AI dey disrupt higher education, instead of use one wey dem build somewhere else, and dis na exactly di Global South-led, equity-centred approach wey Wits AHEAD dey support.

University of the Witwatersrand. (2026, November 9). Wits launches the Global Higher Education Futures Centre. wits.ac.za/news/latest-news/research-news/2026/2026-11/wits-launches-the-global-higher-education-futures-centre.html

AI-generated 'slop' papers published under prominent academics' names without their consent

Times Higher Education · 9 November 2026 · Pillar 6: Responsible AI and policy. For Pillar 6, dis one show how generative AI fit use create not just research findings, but researchers' own identity too, na why responsible AI policy for higher education must reach publishing integrity, no be only classroom.

Asaf, S. (2026, November 9). 'AI slop' papers published under prominent academics' names. *Times Higher Education*. timeshighereducation.com/news/ai-slop-papers-published-under-prominent-academics-names

Wording of university generative AI policies shapes how students and teachers actually behave, study finds

arXiv preprint (University of Maryland and University of Iowa researchers) · 8 November 2026 · Pillar 1: Generative AI in higher education. For Pillar 1, dis study remind us say generative AI policy no fit better pass how dem word am: universities wey dey write or change dia own rules on AI for teaching and assessment need to test no be only wetin di rule allow, but how students and staff go read and act on di words demsef.

Mehreen, S., Yuan, X., Nithyanand, R., & Hoque, N. (2026). *Wording matters: Understanding how GenAI policy rules shape teachers' and students' workflows and perceptions*. arXiv. arxiv.org/abs/2611.11072

How deeply students engage with an AI chat, not how often they use it, predicts better coursework, large Australian study finds

University of Queensland and Monash University (arXiv preprint, submitted to the Journal of Computer Assisted Learning) · 8 November 2026 · Pillar 2: Analytics for student success. For Pillar 2, dis finding important for any institution wey dey build analytics around AI tool use: to just count how many time students open chatbot no tell you anything serious about learning, so systems wey suppose support student success need to check how deep di engagement be, no be how many time dem click.

Zhuang, X., Bakharia, A., Gašević, D., & Khosravi, H. (2026). *From dialogue to task: How cognitive engagement with generative artificial intelligence relates to post-dialogue activity and task outcomes*. arXiv. arxiv.org/abs/2611.11435

WATCH

▶ World Bank video: 'small AI', not big models alone, can widen opportunity in developing-economy education and jobs (1 hr 16 min)

World Bank Group (YouTube). For di Global AI and Digital Summit wey happen for Seoul, wey World Bank Group record, dia President, Ajay Banga, open one panel discussion about how "small AI", wey be practical tools wey fit local condition, no be only big general model, fit increase opportunity for developing economy. Nigeria Minister of Communications, Innovation and Digital Economy, Bosun Tijani, join Tridge CEO Hoshik Shin and Amini founder Kate Kallot discuss education, farming and public service, including one part wey talk about lesson wey dem learn from how dem dey use AI for education for El Salvador. Di panel talk say reliable local data, affordable connection, computing power, skill and procurement system na di conditions wey go make local innovators fit scale dia AI solutions.

FROM THE GROUP

12 Sep 2026 **Partnership: Australia join di Footprint map, collaboration wit Murdoch University, Perth, dey develop**
Dem dey explore joint work on AI and education between Wits and Murdoch; memorandum of understanding dey preparation.

12 Sep 2026 **Masters research report don finish wit distinction; di candidate go graduate for December 2026**
One bibliometric review on data-driven leadership and policy design; di candidate don move go doctoral proposal now.

12 Sep 2026 **Doctoral thesis don finish; di candidate go graduate for December 2026**
Dem accept di corrections wey di examiners ask for, for one study about distance-learning students wey perform well well for East African higher education.

THINGS TO READ WEY WE RECOMMEND

Development as Freedom Amartya Sen, Oxford University Press (1999). Di H for AHEAD. Start here.

With best wishes for the fortnight ahead,



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